W. W. Law as a Leader

Walking the Life of Law

Target Grade Range: 3-5

Overview:

A mail carrier walks a route, stop by stop, and makes sure messages reach the right people. W. W. Law (1923–2002) walked a mail route in Savannah, Georgia, for more than forty years. His life had many stops too. He was a soldier, a Boy Scout troop leader, a Sunday school teacher, a young activist, the president of the Savannah NAACP, a leader in the Civil Rights movement, and a historian who worked to save his community's stories. In this lesson, students will ask what makes a good leader and how a leader is different from a boss. They will then "walk the mail route" of Law's life, stopping at each of his leadership roles. At each stop, they will study a letter or photograph from the archives to find clues about how Law led. Along the way, students will learn how letters work as primary sources and why archives keep them. They will finish by thinking about how they can be leaders at home and in their own communities.

What is a Leader:

A leader is a person who guides others toward a goal and helps a group work together. Leaders do not have to be famous, and they do not need a special title. A leader can be a student who helps a new classmate, a big sister who sets a good example, a coach, a neighbor, or a mail carrier.

A boss and a leader are not always the same. A boss gives orders and expects others to follow them. A leader guides, listens, and works alongside other people. A boss might say, "Go do this." A leader says, "Let's do this together."

Being a leader can be hard. Leaders have to make choices that not everyone agrees with. They have to keep going when others doubt them, take responsibility when things go wrong, and sometimes stand up for what is right even when it is not easy. W. W. Law's life shows us how one person can lead in many different places.

Video: Colonial Williamsburg. "Leadership | Citizenship for Kids." https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tXq6UJ4c2A4

What is a primary source:

A primary source is something made by a person who lived through an event or time period, or something created at the time it happened. It gives us a first-hand look at the past. Letters, diaries, photographs, newspapers, maps, recordings, and objects such as tools, clothing, and stamps are all primary sources.

A secondary source is created later by someone who wasn't there, such as a textbook, an encyclopedia, or a documentary. Secondary sources help explain the past, but primary sources let us look at the past for ourselves.

A simple way to remember the difference: a photograph taken at your birthday party is a primary source. The story a friend tells you about your party a week later is a secondary source.

Primary sources are cared for in archives. An archive is a place where people called archivists collect, protect, and organize important records so that people today, and people in the future, can study them.

Video: Social Studies with The Southern Tech. “What are Primary and Secondary Sources? | How to Teach Social Studies Skills

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Tbth_A_Urd8

Letters as primary sources:

A letter is a message from one person to another, written at a certain moment. That makes it a very special primary source. A letter can tell us:

- **Who was involved.** The writer, the person who received it, and sometimes other people who are mentioned.
- **When and where.** Most letters show a date and a place. Envelopes and postmarks give more clues.
- **What was happening.** Letters often talk about plans, problems, and events of the day.
- **How the writer felt and what the writer cared about.** A letter lets us hear a person’s own voice in words they chose themselves.
- **How people worked together.** Letters between leaders show how they shared ideas, asked for help, and made plans.

A letter is also one person’s view on one day. It does not tell the whole story. Historians ask: Who wrote this? Who was it for? Why was it written? What might be missing? Looking at more than one letter, photograph, or record gives a fuller picture.

About W. W. Law, the Leader:

Read-aloud idea: Delivering Justice: W. W. Law and the Fight for Civil Rights by Jim Haskins is an illustrated biography written for young readers.

Purchase here:
https://www.amazon.com/dp/0763625922?lv=shuf&channelId=500&plpRedirect=mhFallback

YouTube reading: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FfFQU2bfmVg

Video: WJCL. "Black History Month Profile: W. W. Law"

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gHLGfC_mt3k

Westley Wallace "W. W." Law was born in Savannah, Georgia, on January 1, 1923. He was the oldest of three children. His mother, Geneva Law, his grandmother, Lillie Belle Wallace, and his mentors, Reverend Ralph Mark Gilbert and scoutmaster John S. Delaware, strongly shaped his life. Law's story shows that leaders learn from other leaders. In his lifetime, he led in many places:

- **Young activist:** He joined the NAACP Youth Council in high school and later served as its president. As a young person, he protested segregation at Savannah's Grayson Stadium.
- **Soldier:** After his first year of college, he was drafted into the U.S. Army during World War II.
- **Mail carrier:** He worked for the U.S. Postal Service as a letter carrier for more than forty years.
- **Boy Scout troop leader:** He was scoutmaster of Troop 49, made up of boys from First Bryan Baptist Church.
- **Sunday school teacher:** He taught Sunday school at First Bryan Baptist Church, where he was a member.
- **NAACP president:** He was president of the Savannah chapter of the NAACP from 1950 to 1976. He helped bring a lawsuit to end segregation in Savannah's public schools.
- **Leader in the civil rights movement:** In the 1960s, he led weekly community meetings and encouraged peaceful, nonviolent protests. He led an eighteen-month boycott of Broughton Street businesses, and he worked to open places like department store lunch counters and the beaches at Tybee Island for everyone. In 1961, he lost his postal job because of his Civil Rights work, and he was later hired back after national leaders spoke up for him, including President John F. Kennedy.

Many people credit him with helping keep Savannah's Civil Rights movement peaceful.

- **Historian:** Later in life, he worked to protect Savannah's African American history. He helped start the Ralph Mark Gilbert Civil Rights Museum, the King-Tisdell Cottage Museum, the Beach Institute African American Cultural Center, and the Negro Heritage Trail Tour, and he helped bring attention to Laurel Grove South Cemetery through restoration efforts.

The big idea: Law, the archives, and the mail route. A mail carrier makes sure messages get to the people who need them. As a leader, Law made sure his community's voices were heard. An archive keeps letters and photographs safe so that their messages can still be "delivered" years later. When students read Law's letters, they become the people who receive the mail, across time.

Teacher tip: Law's story includes segregation and unfair treatment. Share it honestly in a way that fits your students' ages. Focus on the courage, teamwork, and peaceful action of Law and his community, and give students time to share how they feel. It is fine to say, "That was unfair," and to talk about how people worked to change it.

Objectives:

- Describe the characteristics of a good leader and give examples
- Explain the difference between a boss and a leader
- Explain why leading can be difficult
- Identify the different leadership roles W. W. Law held in his life
- Use letters and photographs as primary sources to find evidence of leadership
- Explain why archives keep letters and records, and how they connect us to the past
- Describe ways to be a leader at home, at school, and in the community

Time Required:

Video times are not included in the total.

About 90 minutes in total. This lesson works well as two class sessions of about 45 minutes each, taught on the same day or on separate days.

- **Session 1:** Introduction (What Makes a Leader? Boss or Leader?), Letters as Primary Sources, and Meet W. W. Law (about 45 minutes)
- **Session 2:** Walk the Mail Route, Reflection, and the Leadership Postcard (about 45–50 minutes)

Topic(s): Social Studies, local history, English Language Arts

Standards:

Social Studies (Georgia Standards of Excellence)

- **SS5H6 (Grade 5):** Describe the importance of key people, events, and developments between 1950 and 1975, including the effects of Jim Crow laws and practices (a) and the key events and people of the Civil Rights movement (b). W. W. Law offers a Georgia example from this same time.
- **SS4CG2 (Grade 4):** Explain the importance of the freedoms guaranteed by the First Amendment, such as gathering peacefully and asking the government to fix problems.
- **SS3CG2.b (Grade 3):** Explain why it is important for citizens in a democracy to take part in public life, including staying informed, volunteering, and communicating with public officials.
- **SS5CG1.a (Grade 5):** Explain the responsibilities of a citizen.
- **Social Studies Information Processing Skills (Grades 3–5):** identify and use primary and secondary sources; analyze artifacts; compare similarities and differences; draw conclusions and make generalizations.

English Language Arts (Georgia Standards of Excellence)

- **ELAGSE3RI1, ELAGSE4RI1, ELAGSE5RI1 (Grades 3–5):** Use details from a text to answer questions and explain what it says. Students do this when they read a letter and point to the words that show leadership.
- **ELAGSE3SL1, ELAGSE4SL1, ELAGSE5SL1 (Grades 3–5):** Take part in group discussions, listen to others, and build on their ideas.

Materials:

- Copies of letters, photographs, and other items from the W. W. Law collection for each stop on the route. Copies are best for classroom handling so the originals stay safe.
- A mail bag, tote bag, or large envelope for each group to carry its “mail”
- Eight “mailboxes” for the route stops (shoe boxes, folders, or signs on desks)
- Route map: a large poster or a path marked with tape on the floor
- Letter Detective worksheet (Student Handout 1, at the end of this document)
- Mail Route Passport (Student Handout 2)
- Boss or Leader? chart and cards (Student Handout 3)
- Leadership Postcard (Student Handout 4), printed on card stock if you can
- Chart paper, markers, and sticky notes

- Pencils, colored pencils, and magnifying glasses (optional)
- Stamp or sticker for “postmarking” each passport (optional)

Key Vocabulary:

- **Leader:** a person who guides others and helps a group work toward a goal
- **Boss:** a person who gives orders and expects others to follow
- **Characteristic:** a quality that describes a person, such as kind or brave
- **Courage:** being brave enough to do what is right even when it is scary or hard
- **Service:** helping others and the community
- **Mentor:** a person who teaches and guides someone
- **Activist:** a person who works to bring about change
- **Archive:** a place that keeps important records safe so people can study them
- **Archivist:** a person who collects, protects, and organizes records in an archive
- **Primary source:** something made at the time of an event or by someone who was there
- **Correspondence:** letters written back and forth between people
- **Civil rights:** the rights every person should have, such as being treated fairly and equally
- **Segregation:** the unfair practice of keeping people of different races apart
- **Boycott:** choosing not to buy from a business to protest unfair treatment
- **NAACP:** the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People, a group founded in 1909 to work for equal rights
- **Historian:** a person who studies and writes about the past

[Suggested Program]

Introduction (15–20 minutes):

Hook (3–5 minutes)

- Carry in a mail bag. Pull out a letter copy and a photograph of W. W. Law in his letter carrier uniform.
- **Tell students:** “Today we will follow a mail route. It is not a route on a street. It is the route of one man’s life, and every stop shows a different way he led.”
- **Ask:** Who is a leader you know? What makes that person a leader?

What Makes a Good Leader? (8–10 minutes)

- **Ask:** What are some characteristics of a good leader? Have students write ideas on sticky notes and post them on chart paper.
- Group the ideas together. Students may suggest: honest, kind, brave, fair, patient, a good listener, responsible, hardworking, a good example, a team player, and someone who does not give up.
- Keep the chart up. Students will add to it during the mail route.

Boss or Leader? (8–10 minutes)

- **Explain the difference:** a boss gives orders, and a leader guides and works alongside others.
- Read statements aloud and have students decide: Boss or Leader? For example: "Do it because I said so." "Let me show you, and then we will try it together." "What ideas does everyone have?" "I'm too busy. You do it." "I'll help carry the heavy part." Students can point to the "Boss" or "Leader" side of the room, or hold up cards (Student Handout 3).
- Fill in the Boss / Leader chart together. Point out that leaders still make decisions. The difference is how they treat people and whether they work with the team.
- **Ask:** How can you be a leader at home? At school? In your community?

Why Is Leading Hard? (5 minutes)

- **Ask:** Why do you think being a leader can be difficult? Possible answers: people disagree, you have to make hard choices, you may make mistakes, you have to keep going when it is difficult, you might be treated unfairly for standing up for what is right.

Letters as Primary Sources (10–15 minutes):

Learn to Read a Letter Like a Historian

- Review primary and secondary sources. **Ask:** Is a letter a primary source? Why?
- Show a letter copy from the archives on a screen or in large print. Point out the parts of a letter: the date, the greeting, the message, the closing, and the signature.
- Use the Letter Detective worksheet (Student Handout 1) and work through one letter together: Who wrote it? Who is it for? When? What is the writer asking or sharing? Which words show leadership?
- Remind students that a letter is one person's view on one day. **Ask:** What might this letter not tell us?

Meet W. W. Law (5–10 minutes):

A Leader With Many Stops

- Share this student-friendly summary: "W. W. Law delivered mail in Savannah, Georgia, for more than forty years. But that was only one of his jobs. He was a soldier, a Scout leader, a Sunday school teacher, and the president of the Savannah NAACP. He worked peacefully with many others to end unfair rules that kept Black and white people apart. Later, he worked to save Savannah's history so that people in the future would know the stories. His life was like a mail route, with many stops, and at every stop he was a leader."
- Show a photograph of Law.
- **Ask:** How is a mail route like a person's life? Why might a letter carrier be a good leader?
- **Explain how the archives fits in:** the archives keeps Law's letters and photographs safe, like mail waiting to be delivered to people in the future. Today, the students are the ones who will open the mail.

Activity: Walk the Life (Mail Route) of W. W. Law (30–35 minutes):

Set Up

- Set up eight "mailboxes" around the room in a route. Each mailbox holds a Route Stop Card (see below) and a copy of a letter, photograph, or other item from the archives that matches that stop. LINK to archive items for each stop
- Suggested order (follows Law's life, starting with his youth): Young Activist, Soldier, Mail Carrier, Scout Leader, Sunday School Teacher, NAACP President, Leader in the Civil Rights Movement, and Historian. You may rearrange the stops.
- Place students in small groups of three or four. Give each group a mail bag and a Mail Route Passport (Student Handout 2).

How It Works

- Each group visits a stop for about three or four minutes. At the stop, students read the card, look closely at the archive item, and answer the questions on their passport: What is Law doing as a leader here? Which characteristic of a good leader do you see? What clue in the letter or photograph tells you?
- Groups write their clue on the passport and "postmark" it with a stamp or sticker. Then the group "delivers" itself to the next stop.
- If time is short, use a "mail delivery" option: give each group two stops. Groups study their two stops and then report to the class.

- Walk around and ask: How do you know? Where do you see that in the letter?

Route Stop Cards

Stop 1: The Young Activist

- Student card: "When W. W. Law was in high school, he joined the NAACP Youth Council. He and other young people spoke up against unfair rules, including segregation at Grayson Stadium in Savannah. He later became president of the Youth Council. You do not have to be grown up to be a leader."
- From the archives: LINK to a letter, photograph, or item about Law's youth or the Youth Council
- Think about: Why might it take courage to speak up when you are young?
- Characteristics to look for: courage, fairness, speaking up.

Stop 2: The Soldier

- Student card: "After his first year of college, W. W. Law was drafted into the U.S. Army during World War II. Soldiers work as a team, follow plans, and depend on each other."
- From the archives: LINK to a letter, photograph, or item from Law's military service
- Think about: What does a soldier have to learn about working as part of a team? How might that help a leader?
- Characteristics to look for: responsibility, discipline, teamwork.

Stop 3: The Mail Carrier

- Student card: "For more than forty years, W. W. Law delivered mail in Savannah. He walked his route, got to know his neighbors, and made sure messages reached the right people. Doing a job well every single day is a kind of leadership."
- From the archives: LINK to a photograph, letter, or item related to Law's work at the post office
- Think about: Why might a mail carrier know a lot about what a neighborhood needs?
- Characteristics to look for: reliability, hard work, caring about neighbors.

Stop 4: The Scout Leader

- Student card: "W. W. Law was the scoutmaster of Troop 49, made up of boys from First Bryan Baptist Church. His own scoutmaster, John S. Delaware, had been an important mentor to him. Law passed on what he had learned by guiding young people."
- From the archives: LINK to a photograph, letter, or item related to Troop 49

- Think about: How does a Scout leader guide young people? How is that different from giving orders?
- Characteristics to look for: teaching, mentoring, patience, setting an example.

Stop 5: The Sunday School Teacher

- Student card: "W. W. Law taught Sunday school at First Bryan Baptist Church. Teachers lead by helping others learn and grow."
- From the archives: LINK to a photograph, letter, or item related to First Bryan Baptist Church or Law's teaching
- Think about: How can a teacher be a leader? What makes a teacher someone you want to follow?
- Characteristics to look for: caring, patience, helping others learn.

Stop 6: The NAACP President

- Student card: "From 1950 to 1976, W. W. Law was president of the Savannah chapter of the NAACP. He helped members work together, make plans, and take action. In 1962, he and others brought a lawsuit to end segregation in Savannah's public schools. In 1961, Law lost his postal job because of his Civil Rights work, but national leaders, such as President John F. Kennedy, spoke up for him, and he was hired back. Leaders sometimes face hard times and need people to stand with them."
- From the archives: LINK to a letter or item from Law's time as NAACP president
- Think about: How can a group president help everyone work as a team? Why is it hard to lead when you might lose your job?
- Characteristics to look for: planning, teamwork, determination, courage.

Stop 7: The Leader in the Civil Rights Movement

- Student card: "In the 1960s, W. W. Law led weekly community meetings and encouraged peaceful, nonviolent protest. He led an eighteen-month boycott of Broughton Street businesses, and he worked to open places like lunch counters and the beaches at Tybee Island to everyone. Many people credit him with helping keep Savannah's Civil Rights movement peaceful."
- From the archives: LINK to a letter, flyer, photograph, or item from the Civil Rights movement in Savannah
- Think about: Why might choosing peaceful action be hard? How does a leader help a large group stay united?

- Characteristics to look for: courage, patience, peacefulness, staying calm, working with others.

Stop 8: The Historian

- Student card: "Later in life, W. W. Law worked to save the history of Savannah's African American community. He helped start the Ralph Mark Gilbert Civil Rights Museum, the King-Tisdell Cottage Museum, the Beach Institute African American Cultural Center, and the Negro Heritage Trail Tour. He believed people needed to know these stories. Like an archivist, he worked to keep the past safe for the future."
- From the archives: LINK to a letter, photograph, or item related to Law's historical and preservation work
- Think about: Why is it leadership to protect stories and places from the past? Who do we help when we save history?
- Characteristics to look for: vision, caring about the community, looking ahead.

Reflection and Closing (10–15 minutes):

Back to the Post Office

- Bring the class back together. Return to the leadership characteristics chart from the start of class. Add any new ideas students found on the route.
- **Ask:** Which stop surprised you? Which characteristics showed up at more than one stop? What did the letters show us that a textbook could not?
- **Ask:** How did Law's different roles connect to each other? (For example, how might being a mail carrier, a Scout leader, and an NAACP president, each help him in the others?)
- **Ask:** Why do you think the archives keep letters from leaders like W. W. Law?

Deliver Your Message: Leadership Postcard

- Students complete the Leadership Postcard (Student Handout 4). On one side, they draw a picture of how they can lead. On the other side, they write two or three sentences to themselves or to someone they know: "I can be a leader at home or in my community by…"
- Invite volunteers to share. Students may add a stamp (see the Postage Stamp lesson) or a postmark.
- Exit question: What is one way a letter can show us how someone led?

Cross-Curricular Connection:

- **English Language Arts:** Have students write a letter to a leader they admire, such as a teacher, coach, or family member, and explain what makes that person a leader. (City Manager or Mayor can be inserted here)
- **Math:** Use dates to solve problems. For example, how many years did Law serve as president of the Savannah NAACP (1950–1976)? How many years between the Youth Council and his time as president of the chapter?
- **Geography:** Find Savannah on a map. Locate places from Law's life, such as Broughton Street, Grayson Stadium, Tybee Island, and First Bryan Baptist Church, and draw a route connecting them.
- **Art:** Design a mailbox or poster for each stop on the route.

Critical Thinking Questions:

- What are some characteristics of a good leader?
- How can you be a leader in your community or at home?
- What is the difference between a boss, someone who gives orders, and a leader, someone who guides and works alongside others?
- Why is being a leader difficult?
- Which characteristics did W. W. Law show in more than one role? Why do you think they show up again and again?
- Why might a letter carrier be a good leader?
- Can someone be a leader without a special title? Who are leaders you know who are not famous?
- What can a letter tell us about a leader that a textbook cannot?
- Why do archives keep letters and photographs from leaders like W. W. Law?
- W. W. Law worked to save Savannah's history. Why is it important to protect the stories of a community?
- If you could send a letter to W. W. Law, what would you ask him?

Extension Activities:

- **Real letters:** Students write and mail a letter to a leader they admire, perhaps a principal, a coach, or a community helper. (City Manager or Mayor can be inserted here)
- **Leader interview:** Invite a community leader (a mail carrier, pastor, troop leader, school principal, or city worker) to talk about what leading means to them.
- **Life timeline:** Students make a timeline of W. W. Law's life using the dates from the route stops.

- **Ask an archivist:** Invite an archivist to visit, or plan an archives visit so students can ask questions.
- **Mail route mural:** Create a large class route with a drawing for each stop, and add student postcards.
- **Service project:** Choose a small way to lead together, such as cleaning up the schoolyard or writing thank-you letters to community helpers.
- **Pair with the Postage Stamp lesson:** Students design a stamp honoring a leader.
- **Activity Play:** "Who is the Leader?" game.

Supporting All Learners:

- **Grade 3:** Offer sentence starters ("I see…", "I think…", "This shows he is a leader because…") and a word bank of leadership characteristics. Have an adult or older student read the stop cards aloud.
- **Grade 5:** Ask students to compare two stops, explain which characteristic mattered most, or write a longer paragraph using evidence from a letter.
- **Reading support:** Provide typed copies of handwritten letters and highlight key lines.
- **English learners:** Pair students with a partner, and add pictures to the vocabulary list.
- **Extra time or movement:** Allow students to draw or act out an answer instead of writing.

Student Handout 1: Letter Detective

Name: _____ Date: _____

Our item is a: ☐ letter ☐ envelope ☐ other: _____

WHO wrote it? WHO is it for?

WHEN and WHERE was it written?

WHAT is the writer asking, sharing, or planning?

Which words or details show leadership? Copy one or describe it.

What does this letter NOT tell us? What do you still wonder?

Student Handout 2: Mail Route Passport

Name: _____ Group: _____

At each stop, write a clue from the letter or photograph and a characteristic of a good leader. Then "postmark" your passport.

Stop	**Clue from the source (What do you see or read?)**	**Leadership characteristic**	**Postmark here**
1. Young Activist			
2. Soldier			
3. Mail Carrier			
4. Scout Leader			
5. Sunday School Teacher			
6. NAACP President			
7. Leader in the Civil Rights Movement			
8. Historian			

Which characteristic showed up the most? _____

Student Handout 3: Boss or Leader?

Name: _____ Date: _____

Write what you learned about bosses and leaders in each column.

Boss	**Leader**
Gives orders	Guides and works alongside others
What does a boss say?	What does a leader say?
How does a boss treat others?	How does a leader treat others?

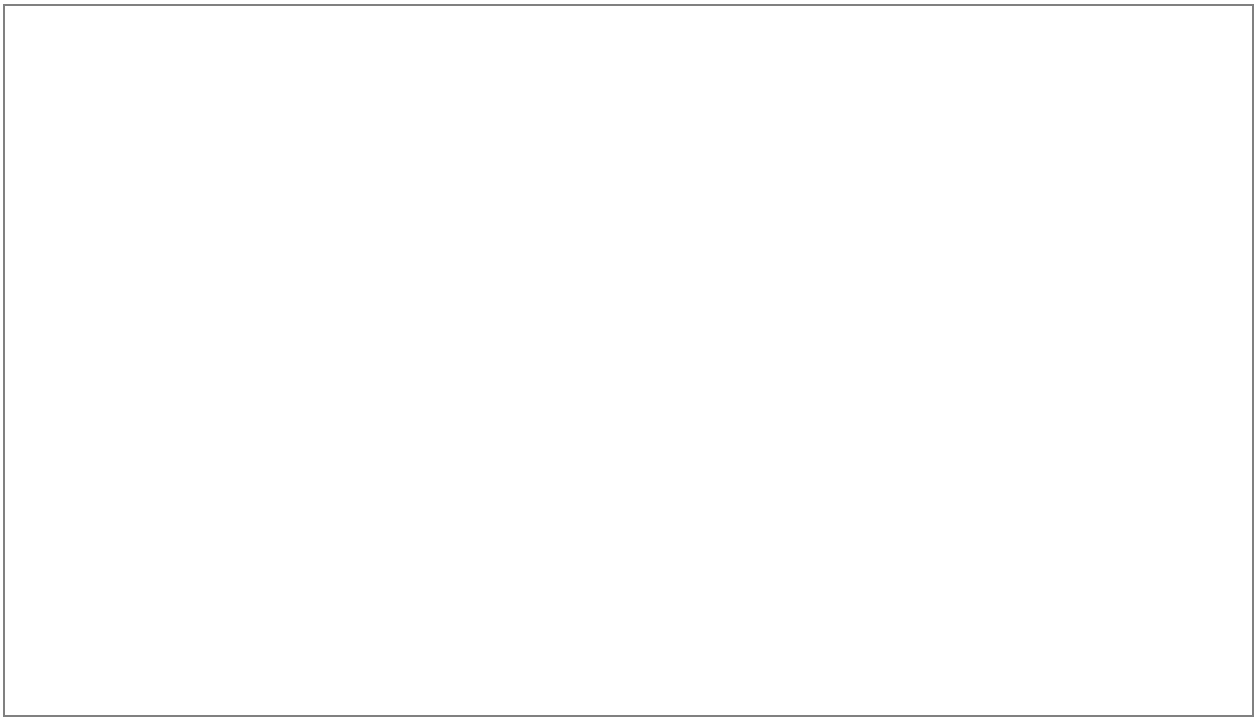
Cut out the cards below and sort them: Boss or Leader?

“Do it because I said so.”	“Let me show you, and then we will try it together.”
“What ideas does everyone have?”	“I’m too busy. You do it.”
“I’ll help carry the heavy part.”	“Stop asking questions and just follow.”
“Thank you. That was great teamwork.”	“That was your mistake, not mine.”

Why can being a leader be difficult? Write one reason.

Student Handout 4: My Leadership Postcard

Front: Draw a picture of how you can be a leader at home, at school, or in your community.



Back: Write a message to yourself or someone you know.

Dear _____,

I can be a leader at home or in my community by…

Your leader,

_____

Game: Who's the Leader?

Directions:

1. Participants stand in a circle.

2. One person is asked to leave the room. It will be their task to figure out who the leader is upon re-entering the room.

3. One person volunteers to be the leader. The leader will initiate an action (such as clapping their hands, tapping their head, patting their knees, etc.) and the rest of the group mimics the action. The leader will change actions, and when he/she does, the rest of the group mimics the new action. The challenge for the group is to try to observe the leader and change actions in a subtle way, so that the "outsider" cannot figure out who the leader is.

4. Continue the action until the "outsider" guesses who the leader is (they can have 3 guesses!), or tell them who it is if they cannot guess correctly.

5. Repeat with a new "outsider" and a new leader. Continue for several "rounds."